

A sample book

Openings and endings

Written for the Chess Vault demo

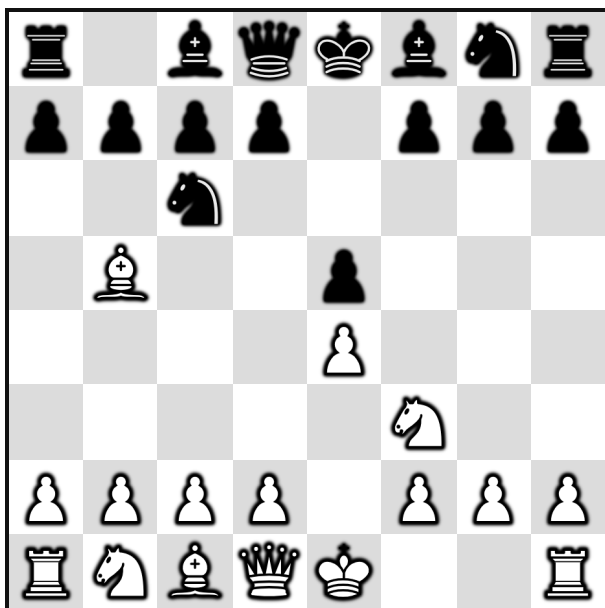
Contents

1. The Spanish bishop	3
2. Building the bridge	5
3. The third rank	7

Each chapter prints one position. In the reader, the button on a diagram sets that position up on the board beside it, so a line can be played out where it is being read rather than somewhere else.

The Spanish bishop

After 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6, White has already asked one question of the e5 pawn and been answered. The move 3.Bb5 asks a second, and the pin it makes is worth more than the tempo it costs, because the bishop is not really attacking the knight — it is attacking the pawn the knight is defending.



After 3.Bb5

Black's usual reply is 3...a6, and the point of it is easy to miss. It does not win the bishop; it forces White to decide, now, whether the bishop is a long-term asset or a piece that has run out of squares.

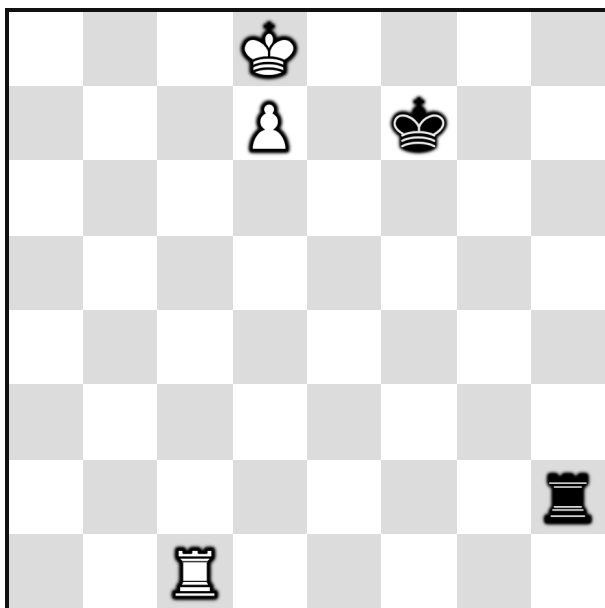
If White retreats with 4.Ba4, the pin remains and so does the question. If instead 4.Bxc6 dxc6, White has traded a bishop for a knight and left Black with doubled pawns — but Black has the two bishops and an open d-file, which in an ending is often the better half of the bargain.

The line has been played for four hundred years and is still not settled. That is the mark of a good opening: not that it wins, but that both sides keep finding reasons to enter it.

1. e4 e5
2. Nf3 Nc6
3. Bb5 a6
4. Ba4 Nf6
5. O-O Be7

Building the bridge

A rook and a pawn against a rook is the most common ending there is, and this is the position that decides most of them. The pawn is one square from queening, the king in front of it is in the way of its own promotion, and the black king has been cut off two files away.



White to play and win

The idea is to give the king a shelter made out of the rook. White plays Rc4, and the rook that looked idle on the first rank is suddenly a roof: when the checks come down the file, the rook steps across to block them.

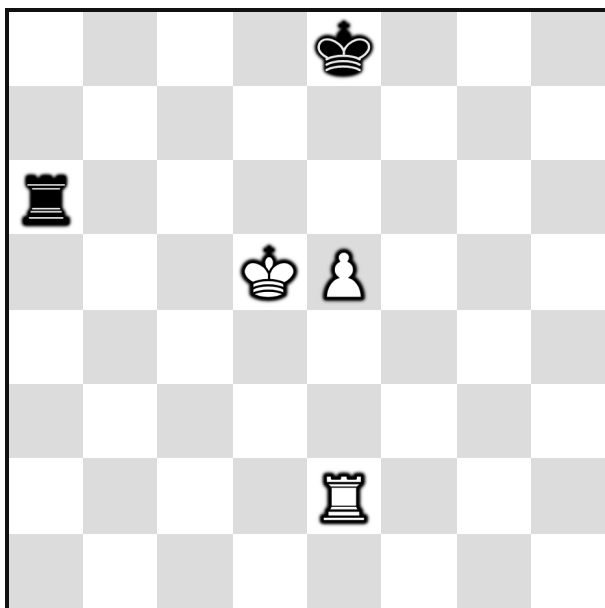
The order matters more than the moves. Rc4 first, then Kc7 — the king walks out toward b5, the checks follow, and on the fourth of them the rook interposes on the fourth rank with tempo: 1.Rc4 Rh1 2.Kc7 Rc1+ 3.Kb6 Rb1+ 4.Kc6 Rc1+ 5.Kb5 Rb1+ 6.Rb4. The pawn queens because the checking distance ran out, not because Black played badly.

Played the other way round — king first, rook later — the same position is a draw. It is worth setting up and losing a few times against an engine before trusting it in a game.

CHAPTER THREE

The third rank

The other half of rook endings is knowing when you are not lost. Here Black is a pawn down with the king in front of the pawn, and the position is a comfortable draw — provided the rook is on the correct rank.



Black to play and draw

The rook sits on the sixth rank, keeping the white king off it. It stays there as long as the pawn stays put. The moment the pawn advances to e6, the rook drops to the first rank and checks from behind, and the white king has nowhere to hide from the checks.

What loses the position is drifting: a rook that leaves the sixth rank before the pawn moves lets the king in, and once the king reaches the seventh the defence is gone.

Two positions, then, and one rule between them. In a rook ending the side with the pawn wants the enemy king cut off, and the side without it wants the checking distance long. Everything else follows from that.

End of the sample.